GENOESE CROSSBOWMAN

During the First Crusade, an expeditionary force from the Italian city of Genoa landed at Jaffa in 1099, then joined the crusaders at the siege of Jerusalem. Like the other maritime republics, Venice and Pisa, Genoa had developed crossbow contingents for naval warfare – they were used to shoot from galley to galley in close engagements. The performance of the Genoese crossbowmen during the siege was impressive enough to establish a durable reputation.

RENOWNED ACROSS EUROPE

It is said that one advantage of the crossbow, compared with the longbow, was that it required little training or experience to use. Even so, European armies showed a healthy respect for professional expertise when it came to employing crossbowmen. The reputation of the Genoese enabled them to find many customers for the services of a company several thousand strong, armed by a guild of crossbow-makers. In fact, the crossbowmen were not primarily recruited from the city itself, but from the surrounding mountainous Ligurian countryside. They practised their shooting in the fields outside the city walls – a source of some complaint from landowners in the area. The company fought in defence of Genoa when required, but otherwise sold its services to the highest foreign bidder.

Experienced crossbowmen were accurate enough to act as snipers during sieges. On the battlefield they were usually deployed offensively, sent out in front of the army to soften up the opposition before the main charge was delivered. To span their bows they normally used a hook on their waist belt: the bowman bent forward, hooked the bowstring and stood up, spanning the bow with the strength of his back. Apart from the bow, their equipment consisted of a helmet, some body armour, a dagger, and a large shield, the pavise. They sometimes fought in teams, with the bowman sheltered by a servant holding the pavise and possibly backed up by another assistant loading a second bow while he shot the first.

Genoese crossbowmen continued to play a key role on European battlefields, even after the advent of hand-held firearms in the 15th century. It is unfortunate that their most memorable appearance on the historical stage, at the battle of Crécy in 1346, was a fiasco. Employed by the French, they advanced towards the English lines but were ineffectual, apparently because the cords of their bows had slackened through damp. Retreating under a deluge of arrows fired by the English longbowmen, they were trampled underfoot by the charging French knights.



Crossbow and bolts
This late 15th-century bow required a lever to crank the bowstring back to its firing position, hooked over the central rotating nut. The bolt was then placed in the groove. Pressing the trigger on the underside of the bow rotated the nut to release the string.



Pavise
This form of shield was most useful when crossbowmen were shooting at defenders on ramparts during a siege. They would crouch down behind it to reload.

> “WHATEVER THESE DARTS CHANCE TO HIT, THEY DO NOT FALL BACK, BUT THEY PIERCE THROUGH A SHIELD, THEN CUT THROUGH A HEAVY IRON CORSELET.”
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> **ANNA COMNENA** DESCRIBING BYZANTINES’ FIRST EXPERIENCE OF CROSSBOWS IN THE *ALEXIAD*, WRITTEN C.1148